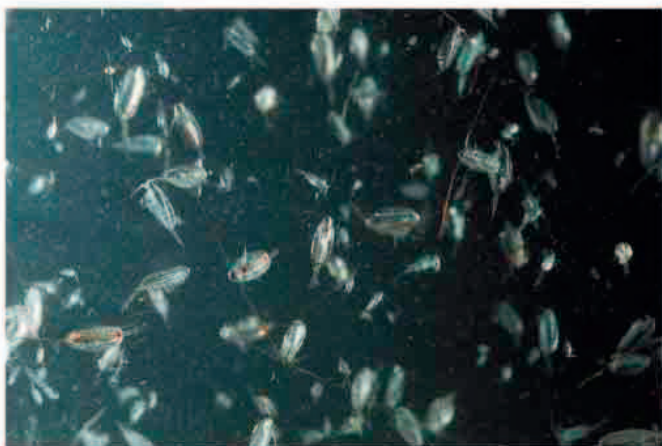


# Life beneath the waves

The world's oceans average 12,470 ft (3,800 m) deep, but most oceanic animals live in the top 660 ft (200 m) or so—the sunlit zone. This is because the marine ecosystem is based on the microscopic phytoplankton that use the Sun's energy to make food. The phytoplankton are eaten by drifting zooplankton, which are targeted by fish. These are hunted by some of the most powerful predators on the planet.



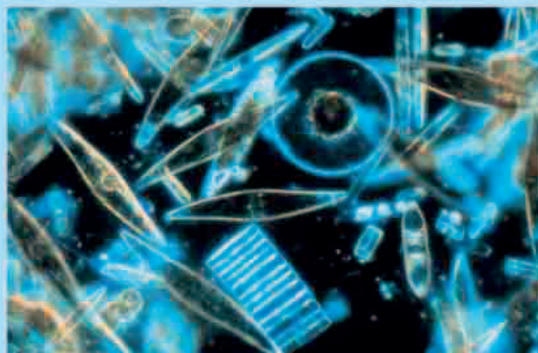
## FREE DRIFTERS

The phytoplankton feed the tiny creatures known as zooplankton. These include adult animals, such as copepods, but also baby fish and the young stages of bottom-living creatures like crabs, barnacles, and clams. By drifting in ocean currents, these animals spread far and wide before settling in one place as adults.



## OCEANIC GARDENS

Drifting phytoplankton are the oceanic equivalents of plants. They are tiny food factories that turn water and carbon dioxide into sugar, and use mineral nutrients to make proteins. If the water of the sunlit zone does not contain many nutrients, as in warm tropical oceans, there are very few phytoplankton. This is why tropical seas are so clear, but support fewer animals.



### ▲ MICROLIFE

*Glassy diatoms and other phytoplankton soak up the energy of sunlight and use it to make the food that supports all oceanic life.*